information with which to make sense of the ominous warning on 7 November 1950, the events around it and their true importance.

CHINA HAD BEEN a source of intense fascination for Nehru since his youth,[32] his writings littered with references to it, and the pairing of India and China as akin and alike, comrade and soulmate, imprinted firmly in his mind.[33] This cultural Sinophilia, combined with idealistic visions of Asian unity and the feeling of anti-colonial solidarity, was one of the reasons that India became the first non-communist country after Burma (now Myanmar) to recognize the newly established People's Republic of China on 30 December 1949. It did so without reference to India's rights in Tibet or the principle of Tibetan autonomy. In this, he was also influenced by K.M. Panikkar, the Indian ambassador to China, who was greatly impressed by the new regime and Mao Zedong's 'powerful and analytical mind', which he contrasted with the 'self-centred and cruel' Chiang Kai-Shek.[34] In full rhetorical flow, Panikkar claimed – or fantasized rather – both Nehru and Mao to be 'men of action with dreamy idealistic temperaments … humanists in the broadest sense of the term'.[35] Patel's advice against any precipitate unilateral recognition, especially without any reciprocal recognition of India's rights in Tibet, was peremptorily brushed aside.

Following the establishment of the People's Republic in October 1949, which both Nehru and his ambassador Panikkar saw as a Chinese victory against Western imperialism, friendship with China became India's foremost foreign policy objective, and India's Prime Minister became China's foremost advocate on the world stage, leading the demand for its inclusion in the United Nations and for a seat in the Security Council. 'Jawaharlal,' states Shashi Tharoor, 'saw it as India's duty to sponsor China's arrival on the world scene.'[36] Borne out of Nehru's Sinophilia and his role as the leader of Asian nationalism against Western domination; and grounded in his belief in 'Asianism' and commitment to anti-colonial